

ENGLISH

Written examination

2025 Trial Examination

SECTION C SAMPLE RESPONSE

This sample response offers an extended analysis of the piece with the intention of helping students understand what they could have written about across the entire text. It is longer than the 800-1000 words students are expected to write themselves.

The petition created by local residents of the city of Lilac seeks to garner further support in imploring the Lilac council to reverse its decision to close its council-run kindergartens. The group appeals to locals of Lilac, as well as readers outside of this area who can lend support to their cause, based on a shared belief in the value of affordable and quality education. Addressing the petition message to the mayor of Lilac, Cynthia Timberland, and the CEO of the city, Bill Davies, reflects the groups' campaign to reverse the closure of council-run kindergartens.

The authors of the petition begin by emphasising the significant negative impacts of the decision to close council run kindergartens. Sympathy is evoked through emotive terms 'despondent' and 'heartbroken' which emphasise the detrimental impacts the choice has had on the emotional wellbeing of residents. The decision itself is metaphorically presented as an 'ugly swing of the axe', characterising the choice as violent and attacking. In this metaphor the connections that exist between residents of Lilac are the victims, with the fabric of the community being the target for the strike of the axe. Lilac residents aim to evoke further concern among readers that these impacts will extend beyond the immediate time period and into the future, implying that the community of Lilac will suffer an "irrevocable" change leaving their council area unable to be repaired and restored by subsequent councillors.

The petition then moves to consider those who are most likely to be invested in and negatively impacted by the council's decision. The axe metaphor is extended as "families" are presented as the group who will suffer the greatest "blow", furthering the idea that the council is attacking its residents. The possessive pronoun "our" creates a sense of shared responsibility for the wellbeing of local teachers and children, urging readers to seek to protect them from this choice. This approach aims to instil all residents of Lilac with a desire

to protect the community, as even if they are not parents, they are positioned as having a direct relationship with the young people in their township. Furthermore, empathy is extended to families, and parents are targeted through sympathetic reference to their “busy lives”, with the implication stress on parents will increase with this closure.

A moral argument is then developed in urging readers and councillors to prioritise the education of the next generation. Motifs of caregiving and creation are intertwined as kindergarten is described as “essential” and “vital”. This loaded language suggests that kindergarten is a crucial and non-negotiable part of a child’s development, urging readers to fear for the children in Lilac if they are deprived of these formative experiences in light of closures. The analogy of building a house consolidates the image of kindergarten as the essential starting point in a person’s life and education. The authors liken kindergarten to the foundation of a house, suggesting that if this crucial moment in life is not met with ideal support and care, any subsequent learning in primary school or high school will be jeopardised as these new structures are likely to topple when placed upon a wobbly floor. The authors subtly imply that the councillors of Lilac are making an immoral, poor and disrespectful decision by suggesting what Lilac “should” be doing (acting with “respect”, “good judgement” and “integrity”). This creates an opposition between the choice to close kinders and the actions residents would hope their councillors would take on their behalf, which by implication are “wrong” when placed against “the right direction.” This visual of children’s lockers, ironically being locked up, compounds this message of children being unfairly treated and limited by their councillors. The vibrant colours and personalised stickers on the locker present an image of kindergartens as catering to individuals in a safe and joyful environment. The oversized padlock and chains that are draped across the lockers symbolise the intervention of the Lilac council and suggest they are barring children from these positive environments. The chains extend over the space where the names of the children might be included, obscuring them and implying that each child’s individuality will be lost when they are ‘locked out’ of the kindergartens where they have made a space for themselves and found a sense of belonging.

The authors extend concerns regarding these closures to financial wellbeing, both for Lilac as a whole, and individual residents. The previously mentioned “swing” of the axe is contrasted to the “upswing” in revenue that locally owned kindergartens create. This encourages councillors and residents to worry about the negative financial impacts behind the choice. Furthermore, the authors monopolise upon commonly shared financial concerns in the midst of the cost-of-living crisis currently impacting Australians, particularly those in the middle and lower economic classes. As these families are unable to easily afford a transition to a more expensive privately owned kindergarten, this group are targeted as being those suffering the most, and set to suffer even more. Anecdotes of common price inflation around fuel and grocery prices are used to establish a connection with readers based on shared understanding of everyday financial concerns in the current Australian economic climate. Specific appeals to women are then made, likening the closure to another disadvantage that women will disproportionately face based on their gender, compared to male counterparts. This appeals to feminist values as “young mothers” are seen as continuing to face disadvantage for fulfilling the benevolent role of “gifting” Lilac with children and fulfilling the role of a parent. In this manner, the authors of the petition are seen to be supporting women and seeking more support and equality for them in society.

Lilac councillors are more directly attacked as the arguments continue. This gradual increase in hostility and direct criticism enables the authors to seem more reasonable and justified in levelling this attack, as the reasons for their concerns have been previously well established. The council are characterised as untrustworthy and insincere through descriptions of their “duplicitousness” and “hypocrisy”. These negative connotations are supported by preceding these words with reference to the council making contradictory claims about the suitability of the kindergarten buildings, offering further justification to defend and support the attack. The authors of the petition undermine the councillors of Lilac, suggesting they are not fulfilling their elected duties by ignoring residents. This encourages local readers to feel their previous support of councillors in electing them to their positions has not been returned. Repetition of words associated with protest and noise such as “pleas”, “speak out” and “louder and louder” encourage readers to believe locals have taken continual and sustained action to stop the decision. However, they argue that this hard work has not led to positive change because of the actions or lack of action of councillors who remain “deaf” and “ignore” locals, opposite behaviours to those expected by elected officials.

The petition ends with a call to action that encourages readers to believe that even though the decision has been made, there is still the chance to have it reversed. The authors describe themselves as being tenacious and unwilling to “give up”, encouraging readers to share their hope for change. They urge readers to share in this positive characterisation of resilience by “urging” them to join their cause. Clear instructions are provided for how to help, by signing and sharing the petition. This helps the authors meet their purpose of not only positioning locals against the decision, but compelling them to take some kind of action to lend their support in persuading Lilac councillors to reverse their decision. This purpose is further supported by the side panel on the first page. The authors have created a template for readers to use to begin their message to Lilac Mayor Cynthia Timberland and Lilac CEO Bill Davies. This makes it increasingly easy and convenient for readers to take action and sign. Furthermore, including the number of signatories and the names of others who have recently signed their support creates the sense that the majority of Lilac is against the decision, urging readers to sign with this majority. The names help to personalise the cause and suggest to readers that the numbers provided are authentic and trustworthy. Readers may also be more inclined to sign their name and send the message, seeing that other people have done so before them, mitigating potential concerns that they may be targeted in a response or drawn into lengthier correspondence than they may wish.